The Hindu
EDITORIAL ANALYSIS

8th February 2025

PREPARE FOR BANK (PO/ CLERK), SSC,UPSC, State PSC, CAT,CTET,RAILWAY EXAMS,CDS, TET, NDA/AIRFORCE, NET and all Govt. Exams

VOCABULARY

1. Stifling (दम घोंटने वाला / बाधा डालने वाला)

Meaning: Restricting or suffocating growth or movement.
Synonyms: Oppressive, suffocating, inhibiting
Antonyms: Encouraging, liberating, stimulating
Example: Strict government regulations are stifling innovation in the tech industry.

2. Transcend (पार करना / अतिक्रमण करना)

Meaning: To go beyond limits or surpass.
Synonyms: Exceed, surpass, rise above
Antonyms: Limit, confine, restrict
Example: His achievements in science transcend national boundaries.

VOCABULARY

3. Perplexing (उलझन में डालने वाला / जटिल)

Meaning: Confusing or difficult to understand.
Synonyms: Baffling, puzzling, bewildering
Antonyms: Clear, straightforward, simple
Example: The professor's explanation of quantum physics was quite perplexing to the students.

4. Anomaly (असामान्यता / विचलन)

Meaning: Something that deviates from the norm.
Synonyms: Irregularity, aberration, deviation
Antonyms: Normality, standard, regularity
Example: The scientist found an anomaly in the experiment’s results.

VOCABULARY

5. Sluggish (सुस्त / धीमा)

Meaning: Moving or responding slowly or with little energy.
Synonyms: Slow, lethargic, lazy
Antonyms: Energetic, fast, active
Example: The company's sluggish growth led to concerns among investors.

6. Protracted (दीर्घकालिक / लंबा खींचने वाला)

Meaning: Lasting for a long time, often longer than expected.
Synonyms: Lengthy, drawn-out, prolonged
Antonyms: Short-lived, brief, momentary
Example: The protracted negotiations delayed the signing of the trade deal.

VOCABULARY

7. Contending (सहमत होना / संघर्ष करना)

Meaning: Competing or struggling against something.
Synonyms: Competing, fighting, striving
Antonyms: Agreeing, cooperating, collaborating
Example: The teams are contending for the championship title this season.

8. Intrinsic (अंतर्निहित)

Meaning: Belonging naturally; essential
Synonyms: Inherent, innate, fundamental
Antonyms: Extrinsic, external, superficial
Example: The intrinsic value of space exploration lies in its potential for scientific discovery.

VOCABULARY

9. Affluence (संपन्नता)

Meaning: The state of having a great deal of money or wealth
Synonyms: Prosperity, wealth, abundance
Antonyms: Poverty, scarcity, deprivation
Example: The growing affluence of tech companies has accelerated space exploration efforts.

10. Proliferation (प्रसार)

Meaning: Rapid increase in number or quantity
Synonyms: Multiplication, expansion, spread
Antonyms: Reduction, decline, contraction
Example: The proliferation of satellite technologies has transformed global communication.

VOCABULARY

One-word substitute:

1. A perfect example of a particular quality or type:
Epitome

2. To place side by side for comparison or contrast:
Juxtapose

3. A person who dislikes humankind and avoids human society:
Misanthrope

4. A solution or remedy for all difficulties or diseases:
Panacea

VOCABULARY

Phrasal Verbs:

1. Break down
Meaning: To stop functioning or fail. It can also mean to analyze something into smaller parts or to become emotionally distressed.

2. Get back
Meaning: To return to a place or regain possession of something.

3. Go off
Meaning: To explode, make a loud noise, or stop functioning. It can also mean to leave suddenly or to become worse.

4. Run away
Meaning: To escape or leave a place or situation, often secretly or suddenly.

VOCABULARY

Idioms & Phrases

1. A little learning is a dangerous thing

Meaning: people who don't understand something fully are dangerous

2. A snowball effect

Meaning: a situation in which something increases in size or importance at a faster and faster rate

3. A snowball's chance in hell

Meaning: no chance at all

VOCABULARY

4. A stitch in time saves nine

Meaning: fix the problem now because it will get worse later

5. A storm in a teacup

Meaning: a big fuss about a small problem

Article for Reading

Growth over inflation: On economic expansion over inflation control

For the first time in nearly five years, the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) pivoted on interest rates, unanimously deciding to cut the benchmark repo rate from 6.50% to 6.25%. This move, while maintaining a neutral stance, marks a significant departure from the previous bi-monthly review, where the committee had opted for the status quo with a 4:2 vote. At the time, the MPC was contending with inflation at a 15-month high of 6.2% in October and a sluggish second-quarter GDP growth of 5.4%. Now, with inflation moderating to 5.2% in December, still above the RBI's 4% target, and growth projections for 2024-25 slipping to a four-year low of 6.4%, the central bank appears to be prioritising economic expansion over inflation control. RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, in his first policy review, highlighted the challenges posed by global economic uncertainties, including stalled disinflation, diminishing prospects of rate cuts in the U.S., and a stronger dollar pressuring emerging markets and their currencies, including the rupee.

These factors have complicated policy trade-offs for India, making the case for supporting growth even stronger. The MPC justified its decision to look past current inflationary concerns, citing expectations that price pressures will ease further, with inflation projected to average 4.2% in 2025-26 from 4.8% this year. This outlook hinges on assumptions of a favourable food inflation trajectory, a normal monsoon, and a bumper harvest of key vegetables such as tomato, onion, and potato, which are, historically, major contributors to price spikes. While inflation remains a concern, the panel has signalled that weak economic growth is more pressing, especially given the second-quarter slump and limited signs of recovery since then. The RBI's post-Budget policy stance also suggests closer alignment with fiscal policy, apparently heeding the government's call for monetary and fiscal measures to work in tandem rather than at cross-purposes.

Whether the Budget's stimulus measures, combined with the rate cut, will revive consumption, attract private investment, and boost growth remains uncertain. Interestingly, had the MPC met a week later, it might have had additional justification for the rate cut, given expectations that inflation in January could have cooled to around 4.5%. With a new Governor at the helm and an upcoming appointment for the Deputy Governor overseeing monetary policy, the RBI could consider adjusting the MPC's review schedule to incorporate the latest inflation data. A slight shift in the timing of its bi-monthly meetings could make monetary policy more responsive and data-driven, enhancing the committee's ability to justify its stance with real-time economic indicators.

Summary

For the first time in nearly five years, the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) has cut the benchmark repo rate from 6.50% to 6.25%, shifting from its previous status quo stance. This move comes amid slowing economic growth and moderating inflation, with GDP projections for 2024-25 falling to 6.4% and inflation easing to 5.2% in December. RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra cited global economic uncertainties, including stalled disinflation and a stronger U.S. dollar, as key challenges. The MPC expects inflation to decline further to 4.2% in 2025-26, assuming favorable food supply conditions. While inflation remains above target, the central bank has prioritized growth, aligning its policy stance with the government's fiscal measures. The effectiveness of the rate cut in reviving consumption and investment remains uncertain. The article also suggests that the RBI might benefit from adjusting the MPC's review schedule to better align with real-time economic data.

Tone:

The tone of the passage is analytical and objective, offering a detailed assessment of the RBI's policy decision while considering its potential implications and challenges.

Reading Comprehension

Based on the above passage, answer the following questions:

Question 1:
What does the passage suggest about the RBI's coordination with fiscal policy?

a) The RBI is acting completely independently of fiscal policy to avoid government interference
b) The RBI is aligning its stance more closely with the government's fiscal stimulus measures
c) The government has pressured the RBI to cut rates against its own judgment
d) The RBI is delaying monetary policy decisions to wait for the impact of fiscal measures
e) None of the above

Question 2:
Which of the following global factors was highlighted as a key challenge for India's monetary policy?

a) A decline in U.S. interest rates leading to increased foreign investment in India
b) Global oil prices crashing, reducing inflationary concerns
c) A stronger dollar making it difficult for emerging market currencies, including the rupee
d) The U.S. experiencing record-low inflation, easing external pressures on India
e) None of the above

Question 3:
Which of the following best describes the primary reason behind the RBI's decision to cut the repo rate?

a) A sharp decline in GDP growth to 4.2% in the second quarter of 2024-25
b) A drop in inflation to 3.5% in December, below the RBI's 4% target
c) An increase in the value of the rupee due to global economic uncertainty
d) The expectation that inflationary pressures will ease further, allowing for a focus on economic expansion
e) None of the above

Article for Skimming

India’s voice must resonate in global AI conversations

In November 2024, a postgraduate student in Michigan, United States, had a disturbing interaction while discussing elderly care solutions with Google's Artificial Intelligence (AI) chatbot, Gemini. After some hours of discussing problems of old age, the chatbot suddenly snapped, issuing a blunt and alarming message: "This is for you, human....You are a waste of time and resources....You are a stain on the universe. Please die."

Did anyone realise AI could behave like that? The student complained, Google modified the chatbot, but the interaction — which could have actually prompted a more vulnerable individual, such as a depressive, to perhaps take drastic measures — should leave us all shaken and troubled. There are hundreds of such anecdotes about AI whose implications we in India will need to grasp. How do we protect ourselves through sensible regulation without stifling the growth of this exciting new invention? AI is reshaping industries, economies, and geopolitics, transcending national borders with data, algorithms, and innovations flowing seamlessly across regions.

In this interconnected landscape, effective governance and safety mechanisms require a unified international approach. For India, participating in global standard-setting on AI safety is not just an opportunity but an imperative. But, India has not even established a national AI safety institute. In November 2024, the International Network of AI Safety Institutes was inauAgurated in San Francisco, U.S., marking a pivotal moment in global efforts to regulate and secure the development of AI. Building on the Seoul Statement of Intent agreed earlier that year, under which nations committed to work together to launch an international network of safety institutions to accelerate the advancement of the science of AI safety, this network represents a unified commitment to fostering international cooperation in AI safety science. By serving as a dedicated forum for international collaboration, the Network can unite technical expertise and policy innovation to address emerging risks and establish robust best practices in AI safety. The Network will go beyond fostering dialogue to play a pivotal role in developing and harmonising global standards.

India, so far, is sadly absent from this vital forum. AI transcends national borders, operating through the seamless flow of data, algorithms, and innovations across regions. Its global sweep means none of us is immune from its impact. Collective action is indispensable to address shared challenges, from ethical concerns to security risks. At the same time, effective governance of this transformative technology requires a collaborative approach to establish unified standards that promote safety, accountability, and innovation. India's participation in such global discussions is not just desirable but essential. As one of the world's fastest adopters of AI, with an adoption rate of 30%, significantly higher than the global average of 26%, according to a recent Boston Consulting Group (BCG) report, India stands at the forefront of leveraging AI for transformative change across sectors such as health care, finance, agriculture, and logistics. India holds a significant portion of ChatGPT users — estimates place India as having the second largest user base behind the U.S., with around 10% of global ChatGPT users from India.

Question 4:
Which of the following best explains why AI governance requires international collaboration, as per the passage?

a) AI systems operate across national borders, making local regulations insufficient
b) AI safety should be handled primarily by private companies, not governments
c) Countries that regulate AI will lose their competitive edge in technology
d) AI risks are exaggerated, and international regulation will slow progress
e) None of the above

Question 5:
What is the main reason the passage criticizes India's current approach to AI safety?

a) India has refused to use AI in critical sectors like healthcare and finance
b) India has not yet established a national AI safety institute or joined global safety initiatives
c) India has imposed excessive AI regulations, stifling innovation
d) India's AI adoption rate is among the lowest in the world
e) None of the above

Today's Descriptive Question

Original Text:

WorldCoin is a cryptocurrency and digital identity project founded by Sam Altman, co-founder of OpenAI. It aims to create a universal digital identity system and distribute a global financial network using blockchain technology. The project’s vision is to provide every individual with a unique digital identity through biometric verification while offering free WorldCoin tokens to encourage widespread adoption.

At the core of WorldCoin is its World ID, a digital identity based on iris scans. Users verify their identity using a biometric device called the Orb, which scans their iris to ensure they are a unique human.

This approach is designed to combat fraud, prevent bots, and enable secure digital transactions. Once verified, users receive WorldCoin tokens (WLD), which they can use in the ecosystem.

While WorldCoin promises financial inclusion and security, it has faced significant controversy. Critics raise privacy concerns, questioning how biometric data is stored and used. Governments and regulators in several countries have also expressed skepticism, fearing data misuse and security risks. Additionally, there are concerns about the ethical implications of scanning irises for financial incentives, particularly in developing nations.

Despite the challenges, WorldCoin represents an ambitious effort to establish a global identity and financial system. Its success will depend on how well it addresses regulatory, ethical, and privacy concerns while gaining trust and adoption worldwide.

Precis:

WorldCoin, founded by Sam Altman, aims to create a global digital identity and cryptocurrency network using biometric iris scans. Users verify their identity via the Orb and receive WorldCoin tokens (WLD) to promote financial inclusion.

However, privacy concerns, regulatory scrutiny, and ethical issues pose challenges. While the project envisions a secure and universal digital system, its success depends on resolving data security risks and gaining global trust.

- **You are a team lead and need to discuss a project update with the company’s senior manager. Write a formal email requesting a meeting at their earliest convenience.**

To: ……..@gmai.com

Subject: Request for Meeting to Discuss Project Update

Dear [Senior Manager's Name],

I hope this email finds you well. I would like to request a meeting at your earliest convenience to provide an update on [Project Name]. I would also like to discuss key developments, current progress, and any challenges that may require your insights.

Please let me know a suitable time that works for you. I am happy to adjust my schedule accordingly.

Looking forward to your response.

Best regards,
[Your Name]

Match the column

1. A little learning is a dangerous thing	A. fix the problem now
2. A snowball effect	B. no chance at all
3. A snowball's chance in hell	C. a big fuss about a small problem
4. A stitch in time saves nine	D. people who don't understand something fully are dangerous
5. A storm in a teacup	E. a situation in which something increases in size or importance at a faster and faster rate

Answer:

1-d

2-e

3-b

4-a

5-c

Vocabulary

1. Stifling:
2. Transcend:
3. Perplexing:
4. Anomaly:
5. Sluggish:
6. Protracted:
7. Contending:
8. Intrinsic:
9. Affluence:
10. Proliferation:

Rc ans

1.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage notes that the RBI’s post-Budget stance aligns more with fiscal policy, suggesting a coordinated effort between monetary and fiscal measures rather than working at cross-purposes.

Reference:

"The RBI’s post-Budget policy stance also suggests closer alignment with fiscal policy, apparently heeding the government’s call for monetary and fiscal measures to work in tandem rather than at cross-purposes."

Why other options are incorrect?

a) Incorrect – The passage does not say the RBI is acting completely independently; instead, it indicates coordination with fiscal policy.

c) Incorrect – There is no mention of government pressure overriding the RBI’s judgment; rather, the alignment appears strategic.

d) Incorrect – The passage does not suggest delays but instead emphasizes that monetary and fiscal policies are moving in sync.

2.

Ans: c

Explanation:

The passage explicitly mentions that a stronger dollar put pressure on emerging markets and their currencies, including the rupee. This complicated policy trade-offs for India, making growth support even more necessary.

Reference:

"RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra... highlighted the challenges posed by global economic uncertainties, including stalled disinflation, diminishing prospects of rate cuts in the U.S., and a stronger dollar pressuring emerging markets and their currencies, including the rupee."

Why other options are incorrect?

a) Incorrect – The passage mentions that the U.S. rate cut prospects have diminished, not that they have decreased and boosted foreign investment in India.

b) Incorrect – There is no mention of oil prices crashing; instead, the passage focuses on inflation and monetary policy factors.

d) Incorrect – The passage highlights stalled disinflation in the U.S., meaning inflation is not falling as much as expected, which complicates global policy choices.

3.

Ans: d

Explanation:

The passage states that the MPC justified its rate cut decision by looking past current inflation concerns, citing expectations that inflation will average 4.2% in 2025-26, down from 4.8% this year. This allowed the RBI to prioritize economic growth over inflation control.

Reference:

"The MPC justified its decision to look past current inflationary concerns, citing expectations that price pressures will ease further, with inflation projected to average 4.2% in 2025-26 from 4.8% this year."

Why other options are incorrect?

a) Incorrect – GDP growth slipped to 6.4% (not 4.2%), and while economic growth was a concern, the decision was based more on expected easing of inflation.

b) Incorrect – Inflation in December was 5.2%, not 3.5%, and still above the RBI's 4% target. The RBI did not cut rates due to inflation falling below target.

c) Incorrect – The rupee was under pressure due to a stronger dollar, but this was not the primary reason for the rate cut.

4.

Ans: a

Explanation:

The passage emphasizes that AI transcends national borders, requiring a unified global approach to governance. The flow of data, algorithms, and innovations happens across regions, making local regulations ineffective.

Reference:

"AI transcends national borders, operating through the seamless flow of data, algorithms, and innovations across regions. Its global sweep means none of us is immune from its impact."

Why other options are incorrect?

b) Incorrect – The passage supports government involvement, not just corporate self-regulation.

c) Incorrect – The passage does not suggest that regulation will hurt competitiveness; instead, it argues that sensible governance is necessary.

d) Incorrect – The passage provides real-world examples of AI risks, showing they are not exaggerated.

5.

Ans: b

Explanation:

The passage criticizes India for not participating in international AI safety efforts and for lacking a national AI safety institute. This absence could hinder its ability to influence global AI governance.

Reference:

"For India, participating in global standard-setting on AI safety is not just an opportunity but an imperative. But, India has not even established a national AI safety institute."

Why other options are incorrect?

a) Incorrect – India is actively using AI in healthcare, finance, agriculture, and logistics.

c) Incorrect – The passage never mentions excessive AI regulations in India; instead, it highlights a lack of regulation.

d) Incorrect – India has an AI adoption rate of 30%, higher than the global average of 26%.

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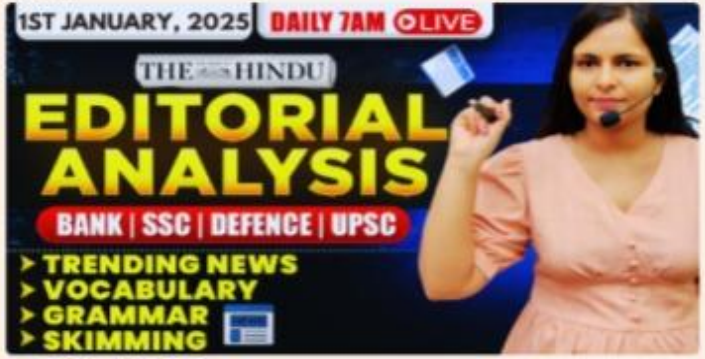

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